

Instructor Guide — Lesson 4: Tell Your Story Professionally

Metadata

Field	Detail
Path	Digital Independence Path > Course 16: Build Your Professional Identity > Lesson 4
Audience	Teens, ages 15–18
Format	Live, instructor-led, virtual classroom
Duration	60 minutes
Tools	Google Docs, portfolio site (HTML/CSS from Lesson 3), Canva (optional, for screenshots)
Prerequisite	Lesson 2 (direction/niche defined), Lesson 3 (portfolio site skeleton exists)
Feeds into	Lesson 6, which reuses the case-study template for a second, more polished project write-up

Overview

Students learn to write two pieces of text that will live on their portfolio: a short professional bio/introduction, and their first project case study. Both must be honest — no invented job titles, no exaggerated impact claims, no borrowed accomplishments. The lesson's core tension to manage: teenagers default to one of two bad extremes when asked to "sound professional" — stiff corporate jargon copied from LinkedIn, or vague enthusiasm ("I love coding!!") that says nothing. The goal is a third voice: clear, specific, true, and confident without being showy.

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to: 1. Write a bio using the four-part formula (who you are / what you build / what you're working toward / one proof point). 2. Draft a project case study using the Problem → Approach → Result → Learned structure. 3. Identify and remove jargon, filler, and unverifiable claims from their own writing. 4. Explain why honest, specific writing is more credible than generic praise of themselves.

Prep Checklist (before class)

- ☐ Confirm every student has their Lesson 3 portfolio site accessible (local file or Vercel URL).
- ☐ Confirm every student has at least one completed Lumexa project to write about (check roster against project-completion tracker).

- [] Open a shared Google Doc or slide with the "bad bio → good bio" demo rewrite (below) ready to screen-share.
- [] Have the Worksheet.md templates ready to share/link (Google Doc copy or PDF export).
- [] Prepare 2–3 real (anonymized or self-authored) example case studies as backup demo material if a volunteer doesn't want to share on the spot.

Teaching Sequence

Time	Segment	Instructor Action
0:00–0:05	Hook	Ask: "If a stranger read only your bio, would they know what you actually build?" Poll the room informally. Frame today's goal: write text that proves skill, not text that performs enthusiasm.
0:05–0:15	Direct teach: the bio formula	Present the four-part formula. Show the demo rewrite (bad → good). Annotate live what changed and why.
0:15–0:20	Talking points: voice	Cover "professional ≠ stiff" and "no buzzwords needed" (see Talking Points below).
0:20–0:30	Guided practice: bio draft	Students draft their 2–3 sentence bio in the worksheet. Instructor circulates (breakout rooms or chat monitoring), gives 1-line feedback per student.
0:30–0:40	Direct teach: case study formula	Present Project / Problem / My Approach / Result / What I Learned. Walk through the worked example. Emphasize: result can be modest and still be a good case study — "it didn't fully work but I learned X" is an honest, strong result.
0:40–0:50	Guided practice: case study draft	Students pick one real Lumexa/personal project and fill the template. Instructor spot-checks for fabricated claims or vague filler.
0:50–0:57	Peer share + discussion	2–3 volunteers read their bio or case study aloud. Class gives one specific piece of feedback each ("that's clear" / "that sentence could be more specific"). Run 1–2 discussion questions.
0:57–1:00	Lesson close	Recap formulas, assign remaining draft as homework, preview Lesson 6 (this same template gets reused and refined).

Talking Points: Professional-but-Authentic Voice

"Professional does not mean stiff or formal." Professional writing is clear, specific, and respectful of the reader's time. It is not passive voice, not third person ("Jordan is a highly motivated individual..."), and not a thesaurus exercise. A 16-year-old writing plainly about a real project they built sounds more professional than a 16-year-old copying corporate phrasing they don't fully understand.

"You don't need buzzwords to sound credible — you need specifics." Words like "passionate," "synergy," "detail-oriented," "team player," and "results-driven" are filler because they are unverifiable and generic — anyone can claim them. Replace every buzzword with a fact: not "I'm passionate about coding" but "I've built three web pages and I'm currently learning JavaScript to make them interactive."

"Confidence comes from precision, not adjectives." Compare "I'm a hardworking and creative developer" (adjectives, no proof) to "I built a weather app that pulls live data from an API and redesigned it twice after user feedback" (proof, no adjectives needed). The second sentence does the bragging for you.

"Honest and small beats impressive and false." If a project only partly worked, say so. "The site's mobile layout still needs work" is a mark of self-awareness, not a weakness — real developers describe limitations of their own work constantly.

Demo Rewrite (Screen-Share This)

Bad, generic bio:

Hi! My name is Jordan and I am a passionate, hardworking, and detail-oriented individual who loves coding and technology! I am a team player who is always eager to learn new things and take on exciting new challenges. I hope to one day work at a big tech company and change the world with my innovative ideas!

What's wrong with it: every sentence could be copy-pasted onto any student's page with zero changes. No project is named. No skill is named. "Change the world" and "innovative ideas" are unearned claims for someone who hasn't shown any work yet.

Strong, honest bio (same fictional student):

I'm Jordan, a high school student who builds small web tools — mostly HTML/CSS sites and simple JavaScript apps. My latest project is a habit tracker that saves data in the browser so it remembers your streaks. Right now I'm learning how to connect my sites to real APIs. You can see my work at [portfolio link].

What changed: names an actual project, names actual tools, names a specific current goal, and ends with a verifiable proof point (a link). No adjectives about the student's personality at all — the work speaks.

Use this pair as the anchor for the whole lesson; refer back to it during the guided practice segments ("is your sentence more like version 1 or version 2?").

Discussion Questions

1. Why might a stranger trust the second bio more than the first, even though the first one uses "bigger" words?
2. Is it okay for a case study to describe a project that didn't fully succeed? Why might that actually be a stronger thing to show?
3. Where's the line between "confident" and "exaggerated" when describing your own work?

Common Misconceptions

- **"Professional means formal and stiff, like a business letter."** Correct framing: professional means clear, specific, and respectful — plain language is often more professional than stiff language.
- **"I need impressive buzzwords to sound qualified."** Correct framing: specific facts about real work are more convincing than any adjective. If a sentence works with the buzzword removed, remove it.
- **"My case study needs to show a perfect result or it's not worth including."** Correct framing: an honest account of a partial result plus a real lesson learned is a legitimate, strong case study.
- **"Writing about myself is bragging, so I should stay vague to be humble."** Correct framing: vagueness isn't humility, it's just unclear. Specific facts aren't bragging — they're information a reader needs.

Anticipated Student Difficulties & Troubleshooting

Difficulty	What it looks like	Instructor response
Defaults to buzzword bio	"I'm a passionate, dedicated learner..."	Ask: "What's one thing you actually built? Start the sentence with that instead."
Can't pick a project to write about	"I don't have anything good enough"	Remind them any completed Lumexa project qualifies — the lesson is about honest description, not about having an impressive project.
Inflates the result	"My app works perfectly and everyone loved it" (unverifiable)	Ask: "What can you actually point to — a screenshot, a working link, specific feedback someone gave you?" If they can't point to it, soften the claim.
Case study reads like a diary, not a case study	Long narrative with no clear sections	Redirect to the template headers explicitly — have them literally copy the five labels into their doc first, then write under each one.
Bio too long / rambling	Paragraph turns into a full life story	Enforce the length variants from the worksheet — start with the 1-sentence version, then expand.
Fear of sounding boastful	Refuses to state real skills plainly	Reframe: stating a fact ("I built X") is not the same as boasting ("I'm the best at X"). Facts are safe to state.

How to Review Student Work

When checking a bio or case study (live, in chat, or async): 1. **Check for at least one concrete project or tool named.** If none appears, it's still in "generic" territory — send it back. 2. **Check for at least one unverifiable claim** (numbers, superlatives, feelings presented as fact) and flag it: "How do you know / can you show this?" 3. **Check the case study has all five sections present**, even briefly. A one-line "Result" is fine; a missing "Result" is not. 4. **Check tone**, not just content — read it aloud. If it sounds like it was copied from a job-posting template, ask the student to say the same idea "like you're explaining it to a friend," then tighten that into writing. 5. **Praise specificity explicitly** when you see it — this reinforces the behavior more than correcting vagueness does.

Lesson Close

Recap: "Your bio and case study are proof, not performance. A stranger should finish reading them knowing exactly what you can do — not just that you feel enthusiastic about doing it." Assign: finish both drafts as homework using the Worksheet, save them into the portfolio site's content (ready to wire into the actual page in Lesson 6). Preview: "Next time we build on this exact case-study template for your second project, and start polishing the whole portfolio site around it."